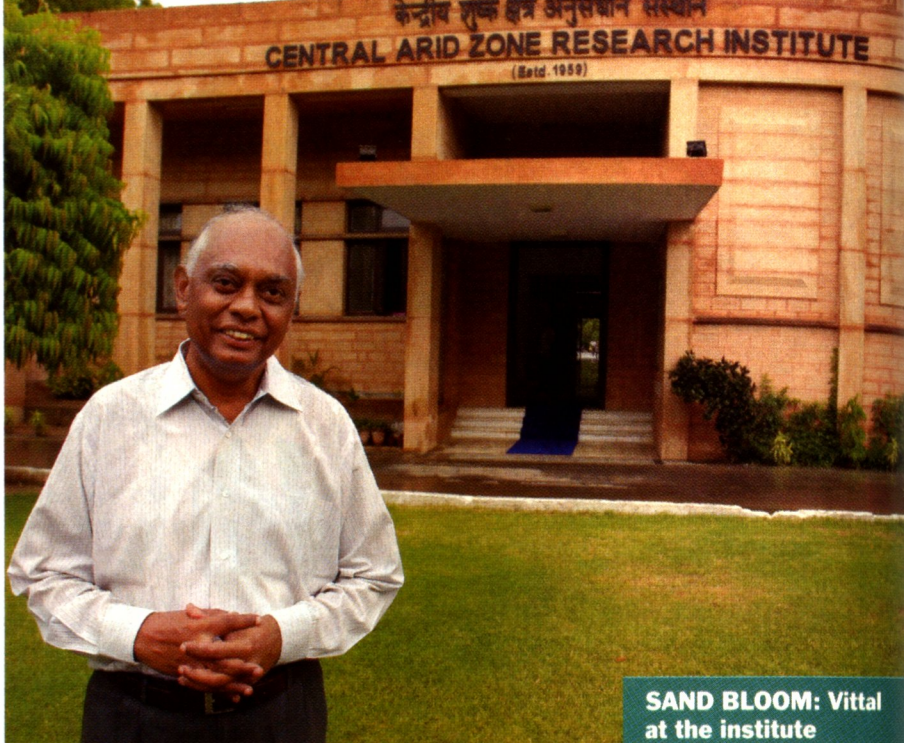




CAZRI, JODHPUR

TOP SEED

The fear that the Thar desert might be marching towards Delhi made the government set up the Desert Afforestation Centre in Jodhpur in 1952, which became the Central Arid Zone Research Institute (CAZRI) in 1959 with UNESCO help. Its success lies in decreasing the number of sand storms as well as reducing their speed. But the masses know CAZRI for its ber species, the Cazri ber, which saw hundreds of farms spring up in the desert, supplying fruit to the entire country. Now it is working on making the *prosopis juliflora* or the vilayati babool a more acceptable tree. Not allowing vegetation to grow near it makes it a much-hated plant. CAZRI has not only developed a thorn-



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

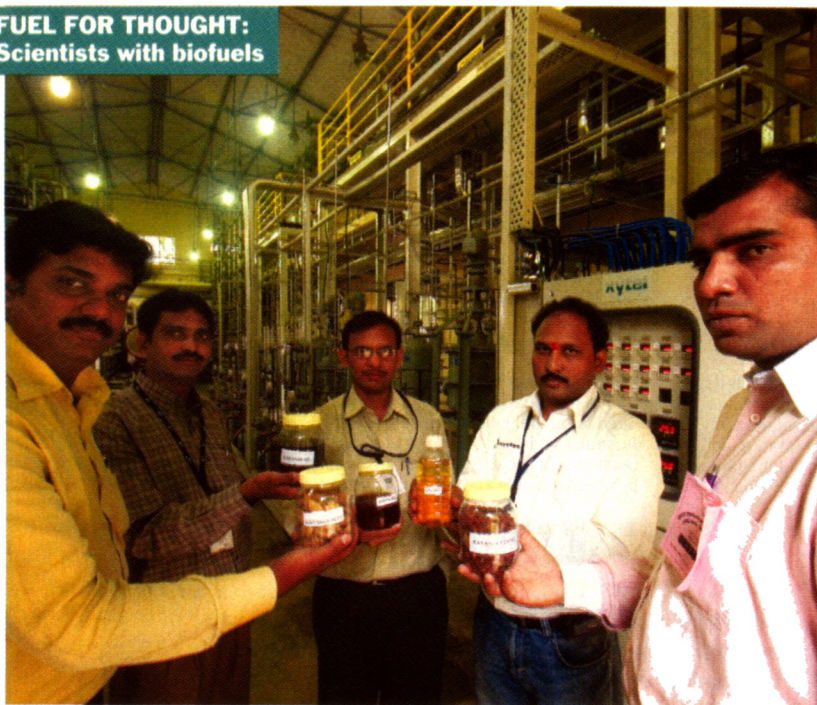
less variety but also an aromatic coffee powder. Says Director K.P.R. Vittal: "We receive queries from the UK for research on babool, particularly flooring." CAZRI also plans to make bread, biscuits, jams, squash and pickles from desert plants.

by Rohit Parihar

"Every desert plant is valuable. We must extract maximum benefits from them."

K.P.R. VITTAL, DIRECTOR, CAZRI

FUEL FOR THOUGHT:
Scientists with biofuels



A PRABHAKAR RAO

CHEMICAL REACTION

Over 150 technologies developed by IICT are now in commercial production. Of the 221 applications filed for international patents, 156 have been granted and of the 97 domestic ones, 87 have been given a patent.

IICT, HYDERABAD

THE ALCHEMIST

Born of a firman signed by the Nizam of Hyderabad to tap the erstwhile princely state's natural resources, the cutting edge Indian Institute of Chemical Technology (IICT) is working on facilitating India's entry into the World Trade Organisation regime. Engaged in world class basic and applied research in chemical sciences and technology, it is currently working on producing biodiesel from jatropha and karanja seeds. "Our research ethos enables scientists to file quality patents in India and abroad," says IICT Director J.S. Yadav. The institute has successfully developed globally competitive technologies in drugs and agro-chemicals and is collaborating with MNCs. Its wide range of research work includes developing not only herbal drugs but also strengthening competencies in the areas of asthma, HIV, tuberculosis and malaria. IICT is now setting up a molecular bank that will have a depository of chemical compounds.

by Amarnath K. Menon